

Somehow I overlooked the minivan, which soon became the most successful vehicle Chrysler ever made, and the L'eggs of the 1980s. But at least I could sense that the company was doing something right. Lately Chrysler has stretched the minivan and added a bigger engine, which is what the customers wanted, and Chrysler minivans alone now represent three percent of the cars and trucks sold in the U.S. I may buy one for myself as soon as my eleven-year-old AMC Concord totally rusts out.

It's amazing how much analysis of the auto industry you can do in the parking lots of ski lodges, shopping centers, bowling alleys, or churches. Every time I see a Chrysler minivan or a Ford Taurus (Ford is still one of my biggest holdings) parked with a driver in it, I saunter over and ask "How do you like it?" and "How long have you owned it?" and "Would you recommend it?" So far, the answers are one hundred percent positive, which bodes well for Ford and Chrysler. Carolyn, meanwhile, is busy inside the stores, doing analysis on The Limited, Pier 1 Imports, and McDonald's new salads.

The more homogeneous the country gets, the more likely that what's popular in one shopping center will also be popular in all the other shopping centers. Think of all the brand names and products whose success or failure you've correctly predicted.

Why then didn't I buy OshKosh B'Gosh when our children have grown up in those wonderful OshKosh bib overalls? Why did I talk myself out of investing in Reebok because one of my wife's friends complained that the shoes hurt her feet? Imagine missing a five-bagger because the neighbor gave a pair of sneakers a bad review. Nothing is ever easy in this business.

READING THE REPORTS

It's no surprise why so many annual reports end up in the garbage can. The text on the glossy pages is the understandable part, and that's generally useless, and the numbers in the back are incomprehensible, and that's supposed to be important. But there's a way to get something out of an annual report in a few minutes, which is all the time I spend with one.

Consider the 1987 annual report of Ford. It has a nice cover shot of the back end of a Lincoln Continental, photographed by Tom Wojnowski, and inside there's a flattering tribute to Henry Ford II and a photograph of him standing in front of a portrait of his grandfather, Henry I. There's a friendly message to stockholders, a treatise on corporate culture, and mention of the fact that Ford sponsored an exhibition of the works of Beatrix Potter, creator of Peter Rabbit.

I flip past all that and turn directly to the Consolidated Balance Sheet printed on the cheaper paper on [of the report](#) (see charts). (That's a rule with annuals